When Rajeev Srinivas discovered he had diabetes in 2013, his first thought was, "This isn't so bad. I can survive without sweets." In the past 10 years, the now 52-year-old software engineer from Bengaluru says diabetes has impacted his life far beyond sweets. "I have vision problems, which means I cannot drive after nightfall. There are also early signs of kidney and heart troubles," he says. Even though Srinivas, who has Type 2 diabetes, is on medication, there have been times when he has cheated on the 'no added sugar' mandate. "Even the occasional spoon of sugar in my tea is too much for my body," he says. The inability to process sudden spikes of sugar has been slowly poisoning his system. There are millions like Srinivas in India, and their numbers are accelerating at an unprecedented pace.

India has the highest number of diabetics in the world. In 2020, the International Diabetes Federation estimated around 77 million Indians to have the disease. That figure has risen by nearly 30 million in just three years. A July 2023 study by the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR), the Madras Diabetes Research Foundation and the Union health ministry found that 101 million people are living with diabetes; another 136 million people are in pre-diabetes stages (research suggests nearly half of them may have diabetes in the next five years). This means almost a sixth of our population is either diabetic or teetering on its brink. The 12-year-long study, the largest of its kind, used a representative sample of over 113,000 people across 31 states and Union territories. "Diabetes is a growing problem," says Dr Sunil Kumar Mishra, who is with the endocrinology department at Medanta - The Medicity, Gurugram. "The issue should be taken very seriously."

Both Type 1 and Type 2 diabetes are diseases that affect the way the body regulates blood sugar or glucose. The agent of that crucial function is the essential hormone Insulin, which is made by beta cells in the pancreas, and which moves glucose (which comes from food) in the blood into cells in organs all over the body, where it's used to generate life-giving energy. Type 2 diabetes is a result of insulin resistance—meaning the cells in muscles, fat, and liver don't respond well to insulin and can't absorb glucose from the blood. The extra glucose in the blood stays in the system, resulting in pre-diabetes and then, over time, full-blown diabetes. Too much blood sugar in the bloodstream can affect the heart, kidney and vision. Type 1 diabetes is an autoimmune disease that causes the immune system to attack and destroy beta cells, resulting in the pancreas's inability to produce insulin. There is no definite cure for Type 1 diabetes, and patients have to take insulin regularly. Type 2 diabetes, which develops over many years and is related to lifestyle issues such obesity and inactivity, can be managed with diet and exercise, though other medication may be required.

"The problem with diabetes is that the excess sugar in blood causes almost difficult-to-manage complications like heart attacks, cerebral strokes, kidney failure and infected limbs that have to be amputated. These are a huge burden to individuals and their families, to society and the country," says Dr B. Sesikaran, former director of the ICMR-National Institute of Nutrition in Hyderabad.

Even more concerning is the fact that though diabetes was once projected as a lifestyle disease among well-off urban dwellers, it has insidiously



"CASES OF DIABETES IN RURAL AREAS ARE RISING FAST. PEOPLE COME TO CITIES AND PICK UP THE URBAN LIFESTYLE. THEN THEY TAKE IT BACK WITH THEM"

DR DHEERAJ KAPOOR
Head, Endocrinology, Kokilaben Dhirubhai Ambani Hospital, Mumbai